Your AI Ministry *Assistant*

Keep up with email and Slack, start every day with a briefing, turn meeting notes into tasks, and clean up your drives. A church leader's guide with copy-and-paste prompts.

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```
MORNING BRIEFING · 7:30 AM
Needs a reply today ..... 3
On your calendar ........ 4
Waiting on .............. 1
  slides from a staff member
Drafts waiting for OK ... 2
Nothing sent without you.
```

00

START HERE

Most of my week isn't ministry. It's keeping up.

Email, Slack, texts, the calendar, meeting notes, and a laptop full of files called "final." None of it is hard. All of it takes time from the people and moments that matter most.

This guide is two things I actually do. **Part 1** is how I use AI assistants in Grok to watch my communication, brief me, help me plan and draft replies I approve. The same approach works in ChatGPT. **Part 2** is how to clean up your drives: the one inside your computer, the external drive in your desk drawer and the shared cloud drive your team lives in.

Start safe: seven rules

1. **Nothing goes out without your OK.** No email, Slack message, text or post is sent until you've read it and said yes. This is my rule and it's not negotiable.
2. **Keep sensitive records out.** Kids' info and check-in data, giving and donor records, counseling or pastoral notes, HR files, passwords, and anything under privacy rules or church policy.
3. **Connect only what your church is OK with.** Use church accounts where you can, and ask whoever manages them what's approved. Leave pastoral care, HR and giving inboxes out unless leadership says yes.
4. **Check your data settings.** Grok: Settings, Data controls. ChatGPT: Settings, Data controls. Claude: Settings, Privacy. Gemini: your activity settings. Turn off model training if your church wants it off.
5. **Never paste passwords or sign-in codes** into any chat, ever.
6. **For files, paste names, not contents.** A list of file and folder names is all the drive prompts need.
7. **AI suggests. People change things.** No tool should mass-move, rename, delete or share files on its own. The one exception is Option B on page 13, and only with the guardrails there. See Verify Before You Delete on page 10.

AI is a fast first-draft partner, not a final approver. People check everything.

01

PART 1
AI AS YOUR ASSISTANT

Daily briefings and triage

Fill in the [BRACKETS], paste it in, then adjust: “shorter,” “skip newsletters,” “only Slack channels I’m tagged in.” These work in Grok or ChatGPT. I use a dedicated assistant for them. Scheduling depends on your plan and setup; you can always just ask.

BRIEFING 1 Morning briefing

WHEN Every weekday, before the first meeting. Set it once and it runs on a schedule.

WORKS IN Grok or ChatGPT, connected to your email, Slack and calendar

```
Every weekday at [7:30 AM], check my email, Slack and calendar and give me a morning
briefing:
1. What needs a reply from me today, and from whom
2. What's on my calendar, and anything I need to prep for it
3. Anything that changed overnight on [PROJECT, e.g., Christmas Eve]
4. What can wait until later this week
Keep it under [150] words. Don't send, reply to or change anything.
```

TIP Name the two or three things you actually care about this season in line 3. A briefing about everything turns into noise fast.

BRIEFING 2 Afternoon check-in

WHEN Mid-afternoon, so you can close loops before you leave instead of at 9 PM.

WORKS IN Grok or ChatGPT, connected to your email, Slack and calendar

```
Every weekday at [3:30 PM], give me an afternoon check-in:
- What came in since this morning that needs me before tomorrow
- Anything from this morning's briefing I haven't answered yet
- Tomorrow's first meeting and what I should bring
- One thing I should hand off or let go of
Short bullets. Don't send anything.
```

TIP If the check-in keeps listing the same unanswered thing, that’s your sign to answer it, delegate it or say no.

TRIAGE Sort the inbox and Slack, don’t answer them

WHEN Monday morning, after a trip, or any time the unread count makes you want to close the laptop.

WORKS IN Grok or ChatGPT, connected to your email, Slack and calendar

```
Look through my unread email and Slack messages from the last [3 days]. Sort them
into:
1. Needs me today
2. Needs me this week
3. FYI only
4. Someone else should handle this (suggest who: [ROLES ON OUR TEAM])
For each, one line: who, what, and what they're asking for. Don't reply, archive,
mark as read or delete anything.
```

TIP Triage is reading, not doing. You still decide what gets answered. The point is seeing the whole pile in one place.

DRAFTS Draft, don’t send

WHEN After the briefing or triage, when you know what needs a reply.
WORKS IN Grok or ChatGPT, connected to your email, Slack and calendar

```
From the messages that need a reply today, draft replies for the top [3]. Short, warm, in my voice. Use what you know from my email, Slack and calendar, and mark anything you're unsure of with [CHECK]. Don't send anything. Show me the drafts and wait for my OK.
```

TIP Read every draft before you approve it. Fix the [CHECK] spots yourself. A draft that sounds almost like you still needs your read.

WATCH Tell me when one thing arrives

WHEN You’re waiting on one email, decision or file and don’t want to keep checking.
WORKS IN Grok or ChatGPT, connected to your email, Slack and calendar

```
Watch for [the reply from NAME about TOPIC / the slides a staff member is sending for Sunday / the decision on X]. When it arrives, tell me right away with a one-line summary. Just tell me. Don't reply.
```

TIP Be specific: a sender, a subject, a file name or a phrase. “Anything important” is not a watch. It’s a second inbox.

WRAP-UP Friday wrap-up

WHEN Friday afternoon, so the weekend starts clean and Monday starts with a list.
WORKS IN Grok or ChatGPT, connected to your email, Slack and calendar

```
Every Friday at [2 PM], give me a wrap-up of the week from my email, Slack, calendar and meeting notes:
- What got done
- What's still open, and who's waiting on me
- What's on my calendar Monday and Tuesday
- Anything I promised someone this week and haven't done
```

TIP The last line is the one that matters. It catches the “I’ll get back to you” you forgot by Tuesday.

1:1 Prep and follow up a weekly 1:1

WHEN Before and after a recurring 1:1 with someone on your team.
WORKS IN Grok, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini. Saving notes depends on your tool; a doc in your drive works too.

```
I have my weekly 1:1 with [ROLE, e.g., a staff member on my team] on [DAY]. Here's
our running agenda and last week's notes: [PASTE].

Before: build this week's agenda. Open items from last time first, then [TOPICS].
Keep it to one screen.

After: I'll paste my notes. Turn them into what we agreed, clear expectations, and
measurable check-ins with dates. Then save it as a note called "[ROLE] 1:1 [DATE]" so
I can find it next week.
```

TIP Measurable means a date and a thing you can see. “Be more proactive” isn’t a check-in. “Draft the January volunteer plan by the 15th” is.

RECALL What did we decide?

WHEN Before a follow-up meeting, or when two people remember the same meeting differently.
WORKS IN Grok or ChatGPT connected to your meeting notes (I use Granola), or paste the notes in

```
Look through my meeting notes from [DATE RANGE] about [PROJECT OR TOPIC]. Tell me:
1. What we decided, with the meeting date and the line from the notes
2. Who owns what
3. What's still open or was pushed to later
Then give me three questions to settle at our next meeting on [DATE]. If the notes
don't say, tell me that. Don't fill the gap.
```

TIP Asking for the actual line from the notes keeps it honest. If it can’t quote it, treat it as not decided.

SWOT Sort event feedback as it comes in

WHEN After a conference, a big Sunday or a series, when feedback arrives in pieces over a day or two.
WORKS IN Grok, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini (keep it in one chat so the list builds)

```
I'm going to send you feedback on [EVENT] in pieces over the next [two days]. Each
time, don't reply in detail. Just add it to one running list sorted into Strengths,
Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats. Merge repeats and note how many times each
came up. Leave out names.

When I say "done," give me the full list, ready to share, plus the three changes
you'd make first next time.
```

TIP Strip names from guest and volunteer comments before you paste them. The list should be about the event, not about people.

BLUNT Be blunt: what's weak about this plan?

WHEN Before you present a plan, a series idea or a big change to your team.
WORKS IN Grok, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

```
Here's my plan for [PROJECT]: [PASTE]. Be blunt. What's weak about this plan? Where will a busy volunteer get confused? What would you cut? What am I assuming that might not be true? Don't soften it, and only tell me what's good if it matters. End with the one change you'd make first.
```

TIP You want the plain truth, not what you hope to hear. If the answer is all praise, ask again: "Pretend you're the most skeptical person on our staff."

KICKOFF Start a project with its own assistant

WHEN The start of any big project: Christmas Eve, a building or visuals project, a launch.
WORKS IN Grok, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini (use a separate project, workspace or chat for each one)

```
This chat is only for [PROJECT, e.g., Christmas Eve services].
What we know: date [DATE], goal [GOAL], team [ROLES], budget [BUDGET], deadlines [DEADLINES].
Give me:
1. A one-page project brief
2. The next five steps, each with an owner and a date
3. Decisions I need to make this week
4. The biggest risks and what would make this slip
Keep everything about this project here so it doesn't mix with other work.
```

TIP One project per assistant keeps the context clean. Come back to the same one each week and ask, "What's next, and what am I behind on?"

> **Where to be careful.** A summary can miss things, so open the original before you act on anything important. Read every draft before you approve it. Connect only the accounts your church is comfortable with, and keep pastoral care, HR and giving inboxes out unless leadership says yes. Never share passwords or sign-in codes with any assistant. And if it gets something wrong, say so. Tell it what it missed and what to watch next time.

How I use Grok as my assistant

I don't use it to think for me. I use it so I'm not the one checking six apps to find out what needs me.

I use Grok, and not just one. I keep separate assistants, each with one job, so their context never gets mixed. That idea runs through this whole section.

My executive assistant bot

One Grok assistant has exactly one job: watching my email, Slack and calendar and giving me regular briefings and updates. What needs a reply, what's on my calendar, what can wait. It reads across all of it and tells me in one place.

The one I work with

A second Grok assistant handles everything else: research, building PDFs, project work and drafting. It's connected to my meeting notes in Granola (granola.ai, 1 month free for new users with a work email; affiliate link), which takes notes without a bot joining the call. More on that on page 9. A few things run on their own schedule:

ROUTINE	WHAT IT DOES
Monday digest	Every Monday morning, a short digest of what's new in AI that's worth my time.
Watch for one email	Waits for one specific email and tells me the moment it lands.
Watch for a file	Tells me when a file or slides I'm waiting on from my team arrive, so I don't keep checking.

Drafts that wait for me

When something needs a reply, I get a draft. The draft waits. Nothing goes out under my name until I've read it and said yes. That isn't a setting I'm hoping works. It's the rule I set, and I'd tell any church leader to set the same one.

Away from my desk

I can call in by voice and ask for research or a summary, and the result is waiting when I get back.

What I'm setting up next

Morning and afternoon briefings for a staff member on my team, so they get the same head start I do.

> **Grok or ChatGPT?** Use whichever you already have. The approach and the prompts in Part 1 work in either. Both can connect to apps and run tasks in your account, depending on your plan, so check which apps and connections your plan offers at grok.com or chatgpt.com. Same rule either way: nothing goes out until you've read it and said yes.

What else I use it for

Beyond the briefings, most of this is me asking the assistant I work with for help, the way I'd ask a good colleague.

One assistant per job

My briefings come from their own assistant. That's the lead example: my executive assistant bot only watches my communication. I do the same for big projects, with separate Grok assistants for things like Christmas Eve service planning or a building visuals project. Each one only holds its own work, so context doesn't get mixed. Prompt: Kickoff

People and meetings

Weekly 1:1s. I keep a running agenda for my weekly lunch with a staff member. Afterward it captures what we agreed, the expectations and the measurable check-ins, and saves it as a note I can find next week. Prompt: 1:1

"What did we decide?" With my Granola notes connected, I can look up what was said or decided in past meetings and prep for the next one. Prompt: Recall

Planning and projects

Event feedback. After our big conference I send feedback in pieces over a day or two, and it sorts everything into strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats in one saved list I can share later. Prompt: SWOT

Planning Center and scheduling. I use AI to turn my notes into Planning Center entries and to draft volunteer reminders. I review them and put them in myself.

Research and honest feedback

Research on request. What large churches use for Christmas color palettes. How example graphics compare to ours. Which resources already exist before I build my own.

Blunt feedback. I ask it to tell me the plain truth about an idea, not what I want to hear. Prompt: Blunt

Building real things

PDFs, checklists, launch copy, a simple website and a store page. I approve each step before anything goes live. This guide started that way.

> **The honest part.** It gets things wrong sometimes, and a summary can miss what matters. I read every draft, check facts and names, and keep anything sensitive out. It saves me time because I still do the deciding.

How I use Granola

I'd rather be in the conversation than typing about it.

Granola takes notes in my meetings, so I can listen and look people in the eye instead of typing. I use it for all of my meetings: 1:1s, team meetings and planning meetings. There's no bot on the call, so nobody has to wonder who's listening.

My Grok assistant is connected to Granola. That means I can ask "What did we decide about [topic]?" or "Prep me for my next meeting with [person]" and get answers pulled from past meetings, not from my memory.

After a meeting, I have Grok turn the action items into tasks in Asana and assign each one to the right person. Follow-up messages are drafted for me and wait for my OK before anything is sent.

Try Granola, 1 month free: go.granola.ai/ryan-spoon

New users who sign up through this link get their first month free. Sign up on a computer with a work email; personal addresses like Gmail may not qualify. I may earn a commission if you sign up through this link.

NOTES Three prompts for your meeting notes

WORKS IN Grok or ChatGPT connected to your meeting notes (and your task app, for the tasks prompt), or paste the notes into any chat

> **Recap a meeting.** Recap my [MEETING] from [DATE] into: decisions (quote the line from the notes), action items with an owner and due date, and open questions. Then draft a short follow-up to the people who were there. Don't send it. Wait for my OK.
>
> **Action items to tasks.** From my [MEETING] on [DATE], turn each action item into a task in [ASANA, OR YOUR TASK APP] with a clear title, the right person assigned, and a due date. If the notes don't say who or when, ask me first. Show me the list before you create anything.
>
> **Prep for the next one.** Prep me for my next meeting with [ROLE OR PERSON] on [DATE]. From our past meetings, give me what we decided last time, what's still open, what I promised, and three questions to ask.

TIP If it can't point to a line in the notes, treat it as not decided. Ask, don't assume.

> **Be careful.** Tell people in the room you're using a notes tool. Keep confidential pastoral care and counseling conversations out of any note-taking tool.

02

PART 2
CLEAN UP
YOUR DRIVES

Three kinds of drives, one safe method

The method is the same everywhere: copy the names, let AI sort them, and make the changes yourself.

DRIVE	WHAT AI CAN REALLY DO	HOW TO GET THE LIST OF NAMES
Inside your computer Desktop, Downloads, Documents	A chat assistant can't see your computer. You paste it a list of names. A desktop app can open a folder for you: see Option B, page 13.	Mac: select files in Finder, copy, paste into a plain-text note. Windows 11: select in File Explorer, press Ctrl+Shift+C (Copy as path).
External drives media, archive, backup drives	Same. It only knows the names you paste.	Plug it in and use the same Finder or File Explorer steps.
Cloud drives Google Drive, OneDrive, Dropbox	Gemini in Google Drive can summarize a folder (eligible plans). Grok, ChatGPT and Claude can search and read Google Drive once connected; some also connect to OneDrive, SharePoint or Dropbox. Some can move, share or trash files, so read the permission screen. Read-only is plenty.	The Google Drive and OneDrive desktop apps put your drive in Finder or File Explorer, so the same steps work. Or ask a connected assistant to list a folder's contents.

THE ONE RULE THAT MATTERS MOST

Verify Before You Delete

1. **Back up first.** Before reorganizing an external drive, make sure everything on it exists in two other places, for example a second drive and a cloud backup. A drive in a drawer is often the only copy.
2. Copy before you move. Don't delete. Move it to an `Archive` folder first.
3. Leave it there at least 30 days. Then ask: did anyone go looking for it?
4. Before archiving shared files, check they aren't linked from your website, Planning Center or an email.
5. Only the owner, or someone they've okayed, deletes for good.

Trash is a backup, not a plan. Google Drive empties it after 30 days. OneDrive keeps deleted files 30 days (personal) or 93 (work, by default). Dropbox: 30 to 365 days, by plan. Files deleted from an external drive often skip the trash entirely.

The 5-step cleanup

Block two hours. Do one drive or one folder first: your Downloads, one external drive or one ministry's shared folder. A small win you finish beats a big plan you abandon.

1 **Audit**

Copy the names out and run Drive 1. Look for duplicates, dead events, mystery files and anything sensitive sitting in the open.

2 **Decide the structure**

Use the folder-structure prompt in Drive 3. Three levels at most. Number the top folders so they sort the same for everyone.

3 **Name things the same way**

Write one naming rule and rename in batches with Drive 2. Start with the files you open every week.

4 **Archive the old**

Move finished seasons into `99 Archive/[YEAR]`. Back up and verify first (page 10).

5 **Check sharing**

For cloud drives, use the sharing check in Drive 3. Remove people who've left and turn off "anyone with the link" where it isn't needed.

WHAT "DONE" CAN LOOK LIKE

```
Church Drive/
├── 00 START HERE.doc   ← naming rule, owners
├── 01 Weekend Services/
│   └── 2026-12 Christmas Eve/
├── 02 Communications/
├── 03 Kids/            ← curriculum only
├── 04 Templates/
└── 99 Archive/
    └── 2025/

Ryan's Laptop/Downloads/
└── empty on the first Monday ← the goal
```

THE NAMING RULE, IN ONE LINE

> `YYYY-MM-DD_Team_Description_v01`

```
2026-12-24_WOR_ChristmasEve-Slides_v03.pptx
2026-11-08_COM_BaptismSunday-Story_v01.mp4
2027-01-10_KID_VolunteerForm_v02.pdf
```

No "final," "new" or "Ryan's copy." The version number does that job, and year-first dates sort in order everywhere.

DRIVE 1 Turn a list of names into an audit

WHEN Step one on any drive: Desktop, Downloads, an external drive or a shared drive.
WORKS IN Grok, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini (paste the list into a chat; free versions are fine)

```
I'm cleaning up [MY LAPTOP'S DOWNLOADS FOLDER / OUR EXTERNAL MEDIA DRIVE / OUR SHARED
CHURCH DRIVE]. Below is a list of folder and file names copied from it. Today is
[DATE].

Give me:
1. Likely duplicates ("Copy of", "final", "final2", near-same names)
2. Stale items: events or dates older than [12] months
3. Unclear names I couldn't identify without opening the file
4. Anything that sounds sensitive (kids, giving, HR, counseling, passwords) and
shouldn't sit where it is

Put 1 to 4 in a table: Name | Issue | Suggested action (Keep / Rename / Move /
Archive / Ask the owner). Don't suggest deleting anything. I'll decide.

[PASTE THE LIST]
```

TIP One top-level folder at a time. It only sees names, so it can't tell you what's in "IMG_4471."

DRIVE 2 Naming rule, then rename suggestions

WHEN Before you rename anything, then again with each messy folder.
WORKS IN Grok, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini (paste the list into a chat; free versions are fine)

```
Step 1: Create a file naming rule a volunteer could follow without asking. Start from
YYYY-MM-DD_Team_Description_v01. Our team codes are [e.g., WOR Worship, KID Kids, COM
Communications]. Give me the rule in one sentence, five do's and don'ts, and ten
church examples.

Step 2: Using that rule, suggest a new name for each file below.
Two-column table: Current name | Suggested name. If you can't tell the date or team
from the name, write [CHECK]. Don't guess. Keep every file extension (.pptx, .mp4,
.psd) as it is.

[PASTE THE LIST]
```

TIP Rename by hand, in batches. [CHECK] stops it from inventing dates.

DRIVE 3 Folder structure and sharing check

```
Folder structure. Design a simple folder structure for [OUR SHARED DRIVE / MY LAPTOP
/ OUR EXTERNAL MEDIA DRIVE]. Teams: [LIST]. No more than 3 levels deep, numbered top
folders, plus Templates and 99 Archive. No folders for kids' check-in, giving, HR or
counseling records. Show it as a plain-text tree.

Sharing check (cloud). Here are our shared files and who can see them: [PASTE,
initials not emails]. Flag anything public or "anyone with the link," outside
accounts, likely former staff, and editors who only need view access.
```

TIP Drive search: `sharedwith:public`, `sharedwith:external` (work accounts). You make the changes.

Option B: let a desktop app do it

Option B makes sense when the mess is too big to paste, like an old media drive or a shared folder nobody has touched in years. Some desktop apps can now open a folder you choose and sort it for you. Examples are the ChatGPT desktop app (Work mode), Claude's desktop app (Cowork, paid plans) and Gemini's Mac app (Tasks, Google AI Pro or Ultra), depending on your plan. Check that your app can see the drive you want, since external drives aren't guaranteed.

Your files stay on your drive, but what the AI reads is sent to that company to process. Treat it like handing a folder to a new volunteer.

> **Before you let it touch anything.**
>
> - Back up first. Every file should exist in two other places before you start.
> - Try one small folder or a copy first, not the whole drive.
> - Approve the plan before anything moves.
> - Move, never delete. Send things to a Review or Archive folder and empty it yourself later.
> - Keep kids' check-in, giving, HR and counseling records out of it.
> - Read the permission screen. Give it only the folder it needs, and choose read-only or "ask for approval" if you're offered it.

What it can tell apart. It reads what's inside the files, so it may be able to separate things like pre-service slides, message-series slides and video files. Check its guesses before you approve.

OPTION B Plan first, then clean

WORKS IN A desktop app that can open a folder you choose (see above)

Step 1 (no changes yet). Look through [FOLDER OR DRIVE]. Do not move, rename or delete anything yet. Give me a cleanup plan with:
1. Duplicates: files with identical content, not just the same name. List each group.
2. Stale files not changed in [12] months.
3. Files with unclear names, and what you think each one is.
4. Anything that sounds sensitive (giving, HR, counseling, kids). Flag it and leave it where it is.
5. A proposed folder structure, no more than 3 levels deep.
Then stop and wait for my approval.

Step 2 (only after I approve). Make only the moves I approved. Put suspected duplicates in a folder called "Review - Duplicates" and anything you can't identify in a folder called "Unsure." Do not delete anything. When you're done, give me a log of every file you moved, old path to new path, so I can undo it.

03

NEXT STEP

If this helped

I make AI prompt kits for church creative and communications teams. Same format as this guide: when to use it, [BRACKETED] fill-ins, a quick tip, and people check everything.

The AI Ministry Kit: Christmas Communications and Year-End Giving Made Simple. 44 prompts for Christmas services, guest follow-up and year-end giving, with 6-week and 8-week timelines. ryanspoonworship.com/#christmas-kit

The Church Creative AI Prompt Master Kit is next. Leave your email and I'll send a short note when it opens. ryanspoonworship.com/#master-kit-notify

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

About Ryan Spoon



Hi, I'm Ryan. I'm an Executive Pastor of Creative Arts at a church in Tampa, Florida. I've served as a worship pastor and creative arts pastor for more than twenty years, and I still love it as much as I did on day one.

Some of my favorite work happens off the stage. I love developing young leaders: spotting potential, giving people real responsibility, and walking with them as they grow into who God made them to be. Watching someone step into their calling never gets old.

At heart, I'm a creative who loves the traditional side of this work. That means planning services, leading worship, building teams, and telling stories that help people encounter Jesus. That's where my roots are, and it's still the heart of what I do every week.

Over the last year, I started using AI tools in our creative world. Not to replace any of that, but to help us work more efficiently and stay organized. They've also made my work better. I can explore more ideas, refine them faster, and spend my best energy on the details that make something great. Most of all, they've freed up more time for the people and moments that matter most.

Want help bringing AI to your creative team? Training, workshops and coaching for church teams: ryanspoonworship.com · ryanspoonworship@gmail.com

Other tools I use: I make animated titles and motion graphics with Malloy Studio (malloystudio.ai, affiliate link).

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